

[Return to Order of Business](#)

TAB 15



Board of Education Report

File #: Res-023-23/24, Version: 1

Mr. Schmerelson- Observing March 21 as Down Syndrome Awareness Day (Res-023-23/24) (For Action March 12, 2024)

Whereas, The Los Angeles Unified School District is committed to academic excellence, joy, and wellness for all students regardless of disability through strategic pillars 1 and 2;

Whereas, The District advocates heavily for the destigmatization of students who have faced either physical or mental challenges;

Whereas, Down Syndrome is a genetic occurrence caused by extra material in chromosome 21 that results in intellectual disability. It is not yet known why this occurs;

Whereas, The estimated incidence of Down Syndrome is between 1 in 1,000 to 1 in 1,100 live births worldwide;

Whereas, Each year approximately 3,000 to 5,000 children are born with this chromosome disorder and it is believed there are about 250,000 families in the United States of America who are affected by Down Syndrome;

Whereas, The quality of life of people with Down Syndrome can be improved by meeting their health care needs, including regular check-ups with health professionals to monitor mental and physical condition and providing timely intervention, be it physiotherapy, occupational therapy, speech therapy, counseling or special education;

Whereas, Individuals with Down Syndrome can achieve optimal quality of life through guardian care and support, medical guidance, and community-based support systems like inclusive education at all levels. This facilitates their participation in society and the fulfillment of their personal potential;

Whereas, The reality today is that society, at times, can demonstrate negative attitudes, low expectations, discrimination, and exclusion, which can ensure that people with Down syndrome are left behind. This can also occur within the disability and the Down Syndrome communities;

Whereas, There is a need to build the capacity of people with Down Syndrome to meet the challenges faced across their lifetimes and to support them with the opportunities and tools needed to live fulfilling lives;

Whereas, World Down Syndrome Day was first observed in 2006 in many countries around the world;

Whereas, In December 2011, the United Nations General Assembly declared March 21st as World Down Syndrome Day. This resolution was co-sponsored by 78 United Nations Member States;

Whereas, Down Syndrome International (DSi) encourages people all over the world to choose their own activities and events on March 21st to help raise awareness of what Down Syndrome is, what it means to have Down Syndrome, and how people with Down Syndrome play a vital role in our lives and communities; and

Whereas, The 2023 DSi World Down Syndrome Day theme is “With Us Not For Us”, the message is a key to a human rights-based approach to disability and is encouraging participation in a video campaign using

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#WithUsNotForUS and #WorldDownSyndromeDay and #WDSD2023; now, therefore, be it

Resolved, That the Governing Board of the Los Angeles Unified School District hereby proclaims March 21st as World Down Syndrome Awareness Day;

Resolved further, That the District will enhance resources regarding Down Syndrome to all LAUSD parents through school Parent Centers and school coordinators; and be it finally

Resolved, That the Governing Board of the Los Angeles Unified School District encourages all qualified staff to observe March 21st, World Down Syndrome Awareness Day, by holding productive conversations with students to continue with the destigmatization of Down Syndrome.